

Cryptography

CSUMB

Sam Ogden

OSTEP 56

Updated 2026-04-29 09:56

DRAFT

This slide deck is still under active development. Expect changes before it is finalized.

Lecture Objectives

- After this lecture, you should be able to:
- Talk about the two main kinds of cryptography
- Discuss how we use cryptography in operating systems and computer science
- Know to never, ever roll your own (at least until you do much too much math)

Major Goals of Cryptography

Confidentiality

- Hide the information from prying eyes
- Encryption

Authenticity

- Ensure the data came from who it says it came from
- Signing

Integrity

- Ensure the data is correct
- Checksums

Confidentiality

Ensuring data is secret

Two main kinds of Encryption

- Symmetric Key encryption
 - Both the sender and receiver use the same key
 - Examples: DES, AES, Blowfish
- Asymmetric key encryption
 - The sender and the receiver use two different keys, the public key and a private key
 - Examples: RSA, ECC

Shared-Key Encryption (Symmetric)

We are given:

- An algorithm (aka *cipher*), E
- Some data (aka *plaintext*), P
- One secret (aka *key*), K

$$C = E(P, K)$$
$$P = D(C, K)$$

We output:

- Encrypted data (aka *ciphertext*), C

Public-Key Encryption (Asymmetric)

We are given:

- An algorithm (aka *cipher*), E
- Some data (aka *plaintext*), P
- Two keys
 - A **public** K_{public}
 - A **secret** $K_{private}$
 - The scheme is public; the keys are what matter

$$C = E(P, K_{public})$$
$$P = D(C, K_{private})$$

Trade-offs

- Public Key encryption is expensive
 - Long keys (thousands of bits)
 - Lots of calculations (huge exponents)
- Shared Key encryption is onerous
 - Either you have many unique keys, or you reduce privacy greatly
- Often we use a mix of both!

Diffie-Hellman Key Exchange



Encryption Summary

- Encryption protects confidentiality
- The algorithm is public; security comes from the key, not from hiding the method
- Symmetric encryption uses one shared secret key
- Asymmetric encryption uses a public key to encrypt and a private key to decrypt
- Good systems use encryption as part of a larger design, not as a magic shield

Integrity

Verifying data is right

Integrity: Core Idea

- Include a piece of information to ensure that a file is unaltered
- We accomplish this by adding in an extra piece of information: a [hash](#)
- Hashes are one-way functions that represent data in a compact form

Features of Cryptographic Hashes

- **Collision Resistance:** Collisions are computationally infeasible
- **Input sensitivity:** Any input change results in large output change
 - Roughly 50% of bits in output should change for any single input bit change
- **One-way:** Computationally infeasible to infer input properties

Computationally Infeasible



Hashes: Collisions

Expected behavior: different hashes			Collision attack: same hashes		
	 Sha-1	 42C1..21		 Sha-1	 3713..42
Doc 1			Good doc		
	 Sha-1	 3E2A..AE		 Sha-1	 3713..42
Doc 2			Bad doc		

Hashes: SHA-1 Collision

- Google made a SHA-1 collision happen in 2017
- It was previously considered secure
- Some numbers:
 - Nine quintillion (9,223,372,036,854,775,808) SHA1 computations in total
 - 6,500 years of CPU computation to complete the attack first phase
 - 110 years of GPU computation to complete the second phase

Hashes: Small Changes to Big Changes

```
7 users/ssh-agent/scratch
$ sha1 1 2
SHA1 (1) = 356a192b7913b04c54574d18c28d46e6395428ab
SHA1 (2) = da4b9237bacccdf19c0760cab7aec4a8359010b0
(here)
```

We change one bit in the input and it changes everything in the output

Hashes: One-way

```
> wc -c 56-cryptography.qmd && sha1 56-cryptography.qmd  
4649 56-cryptography.qmd  
SHA1 (56-cryptography.qmd) = fb1c5078ca0db9333dd868a4c7ae22a5eabdfef33
```

A hash compresses a large input into a fixed-size digest
It should be infeasible to recover the input from that digest

Authentication

Verifying we are us

Authentication: two common models

- Shared-secret authentication uses one key on both sides
 - Example: HMAC
- Public-key authentication uses a private key to sign and a public key to verify
 - Example: digital signatures
- Both prove authenticity, but they trust different things

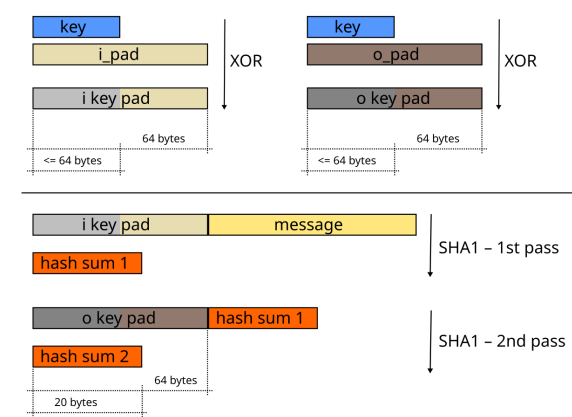
Core Idea: Authentication

Our goal is to prove that we are us, and that we did a thing

- We can do this by sharing something **only** we would know
- We can sign the file with our **private** key, which is known only to us
- Recipient can then verify with our **public** key
 - Remember that our public and private keys are two sides of the same algorithm

Example of Authentication: HMAC

HMAC is shared-secret authentication.



Breaking Cryptography

Common Ways to crack Cryptography

Computational threats

- Brute-forcing keys
- Side-channel attacks
- Quantum Computers

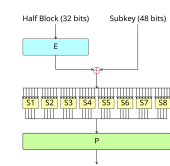
Operational Issues

- Social Engineering
- Backdoors

Design Flaws

- Software errors
- Bad cryptosystem design

Example of a flawed system: DES



Cryptography in Operating Systems

What the OS should think about

- How to provide **entropy**
- How to protect the user against **us**
- How to provide **at-rest data encryption**
- How to safely authenticate users across systems